Case Study: Phishing Attack - The “Internship Offer” Scam

What is Phishing?

Phishing is a cybercrime where attackers impersonate legitimate organizations to trick individuals into revealing sensitive information such as login credentials, bank details, or personal data.

How It Happened (Step-by-Step)

1. **The bait:** A third-year engineering student, Priya, received an email that appeared to come from her college’s placement cell. The subject read: “Urgent: Internship Shortlist – Complete Verification”.

2. **The trap:** The email contained a link to a form that looked identical to the college’s official portal. It asked for her college email password “for verification” and also requested her UPI ID to “process the stipend”.

3. **The moment of action:** The email created urgency by stating that the verification must be completed within 12 hours. Priya, excited about the internship, entered her credentials without checking the sender’s address.

4. **The aftermath:** Within hours, her college email was locked out, and she received a fraudulent transaction alert of ₹8,000 from her linked bank account. The attackers had used her credentials to reset other accounts and initiate a UPI payment.

Who Is Targeted

College students are prime targets because they are actively seeking internships, scholarships, and job opportunities. Attackers exploit their enthusiasm and lack of experience with official verification processes.

Consequences

- **Financial loss:** Priya lost ₹8,000 and had to go through a lengthy bank dispute process.

- **Reputation damage:** Her email was used to send spam to faculty members, causing embarrassment.

- **Psychological impact:** She experienced anxiety, loss of trust in online opportunities, and spent weeks securing her compromised accounts.